- A number of legislative steps have also been taken to secure the *rights of people*, like the Right to Information Act, the MGNREGA, the Forest Rights Act, and the RTE. Thus the funds are in place, rights constitutionally guaranteed, and many achievements recorded, but there are also pressing issues like ***leakages*** and funds not reaching the targeted beneficiaries. While the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system with the help of the UID can help in plugging many of these leakages, there is enough scope for expenditure reduction even in social-sector programmes through ***convergence*** (integration and combining).
- *Economic Survey 2011-12* had pointed out that there are many schemes like the AABY, JBY, and RSBY with significant overlap and catering to the same or similar categories of the population, with Shiksha Sahyoga Yojana (SSY) as a add-on benefit under the former two schemes. A welcome development this year is the merger of the JBY with the AABY. There are many other such areas where convergence can take place. For example the JSY, Janani Shishu Surksha Karyakram (JSSK), and Indira Gandhi Matritva Sahyog Yojana (IGMSY) have many overlapping features and the same beneficiaries. This calls for a
  careful exercise in identifying overlapping schemes and weeding out or converging them.
- A *threshold level* could also be fixed for the schemes as a critical minimum investment or outlay is needed for any programme to be successful. The Committee *on 'Restructuring of Centrally Sponsored Schemes'* has suggested that new centrally sponsored schemes should have a minimum Plan expenditure of Rs. 10,000 crore over the Five Year Plan and should be included under *flagship schemes*.
- Another area needing attention is ***decentralisation***. While Plan programmes are designed with a "bottom-up approach" and are *Panchayat-and PRI-centric*, they are actually imsdplemented in a *top-down manner* and do not effectively articulate the needs and aspirations of the local people, especially the most vulnerable. With the 73rd Constitutional Amendment, several functions were